Speaking on 3 March, VOC said that he was planning to give up his position in SSNCo and instead devote his time to defend everyone against whom false cases had been slapped at the instance of BI. In an emotional moment, he declared that 'Siva and I are ready to be shot if that was their fate.'[33]

The news of VOC's demotion did not go down well with the public. A *Swadesamitran* correspondent denied reports that VOC had left; he was now an agent and was working with his characteristic zeal.[34] The clarification obfuscated the ground reality rather than clear the situation.

Swadeshi at its Zenith

Even as he was fighting the vested interests in the company, VOC's Swadeshi political work moved into top gear. The Swadeshi meetings were held regularly, and the Coral Mills strike was in full swing.

Contrary to what K.R. Guruswami Aiyar and Neelakanta Brahmachari argued, this Swadeshi groundswell only strengthened SSNCo's business. Making a success of the Swadeshi company was intended as a direct attack on British colonial rule.

An incident that took place on 27 February gives a window into the mood of the times. An employee of S.K. Marakayar (likely the same S.K.M.K. Marakayar whose name figured in the first prospectus of SSNCo) who had gone to the BI's office to book a shipment of cattle was 'stopped by a Sahib [a Muslim] of Ottapidaram [incidentally, VOC's home village]', who allegedly threatened him and asked him 'to take the order to the Swadeshi company'. On hearing of this from the police in the town station, the deputy superintendent of the police, the highest-ranking police officer of Tuticorin, personally went across to the BI's office and interviewed its chief executive Eric Chapman who complained that people were being instigated to interfere with their customers and intimidate them as a result of the public meetings. However, the Marakayar's servant refused to file a complaint without his master's permission. Meanwhile, VOC himself had a chat with the merchant and resolved the issue.[35] (Marakayar apparently shipped with